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New laws trigger legal fights over Nazi-looted art

BY DEEPA BHARATH
THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

LOS ANGELES — Jewish heirs of Holocaust victims and their representatives have filed two lawsuits in California staking their claims to Nazi-looted paintings that still hang on the walls of prominent museums in Los Angeles and Auschwitz.

This pair of lawsuits are the first to be filed after the recent passage of laws by California and Congress, which strengthen U.S.-based claims to artwork that were forcibly taken from Jewish families during World War II.

One lawsuit was filed in Los Angeles Superior Court on Monday by the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles and its board chair Daniel Gryczman against Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena for the return of “Adam and Eve.” These are two life-size oil-on-panel masterpieces created by Lucas Carnach the Elder in 1530.

The other lawsuit was filed in federal court in Los Angeles the same day by the daughters of the late Dinah Gottliebova Babbitt, a Holocaust survivor and California-based animator who was held in Auschwitz. It demanded the return of watercolors of fellow prisoners that the artist was forced to paint for Josef Mengele, a Nazi physician who had earned the nickname the “Angel of Death.”

Spokespersons for both museums say the museums legally hold titles to the works, and intend to continue displaying them to the public. The lawsuits don’t specify the monetary value of the paintings.

FAMILIES VS. MUSEUMS

The issue of Nazi-looted art is an emotional, legally and ethically charged topic that pits Jewish families that have suffered inter-generational trauma against museums that say they are trying to preserve a painful, yet important, chapter of history. Between 1933 and 1945, the Nazi regime orchestrated the largest art theft in world history, seizing over 600,000 works of art across Europe from Jewish families, collectors and museums. Decades later, many of these masterpieces reside in prominent museums around the world, making the push for their recovery more complex than a simple property dispute.

GERARD VUILLEUMIER/NORTON SIMON ART FOUNDATION VIA AP
Two oil paintings, “Adam and Eve,” painted in 1530 by Lucas Cranach the Elder, are displayed Friday in the Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena, Calif.

Rabbi Noah Farkas is president and CEO of the Jewish Federation of Los Angeles, the organization to which Marei von Saher, sole heir of Dutch Jewish art dealer Jacques Goudstikker, has signed over her rights. The paintings were seized from Goudstikker’s collection by Hermann Goring, Adolf Hitler’s second-in-command and changed a number of hands before being sold in the 1960s to the Pasadena Museum of Modern Art, which was renamed Norton Simon Museum in honor of its benefactor.

Farkas said the federation plans to use most of the net proceeds from the recovered art to provide much-needed help to the about 2,500 Holocaust survivors living in the Los Angeles area.

“These are incredibly beautiful European masterpieces stolen from a Jewish family to enrich the Nazi party and fund the war and death machine against the people,” he said. “It’s our honor to take on this role on behalf of the community and use most of the proceeds to help these elderly survivors live out the last years of their lives in dignity, comfort and peace — something their family members were denied during the Holocaust.”

Marei von Saher, in a statement, said she is grateful to the Jewish organization for taking up her family’s cause.

“This effort represents a meaningful step toward justice for Holocaust survivors and victims of Nazi era atrocities,” she said.

NEW LEGISLATION

California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, wrote Assembly Bill 2867, signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in September 2024, which requires that the state law must apply in lawsuits brought by California residents or their heirs to recover art seized during the Holocaust or during other acts of persecution. Gabriel, who co-chairs the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, introduced the legislation in response to a federal court ruling, which allowed the state-owned Thyssen-Bornemisza National Museum in Madrid to keep a multimillion-dollar Camille Pissarro impressionist masterpiece.

This case, which prompted this new law, is expected to be heard in federal court in California next month. Gabriel said it’s time for museums to “do some deep introspection on whether they want to be on the right side of history.”

HISTORICAL VALUE

Norton Simon Museum released a statement pointing out that a federal court in 2018 unanimously determined that the museum had proper title to the Cranach paintings. In May 2019, the U.S. Supreme Court declined to get involved in the case, leaving in place lower court rulings.

They said the Cranach paintings, which originally belonged to the Stroganoff family, were put up for sale in 1931 by the Soviet Union in an illicit auction in Berlin where they were purchased by Goudstikker. After a complicated journey, the paintings were sold to the museum by a Stroganoff family descendant. The museum later restored and preserved the pieces.

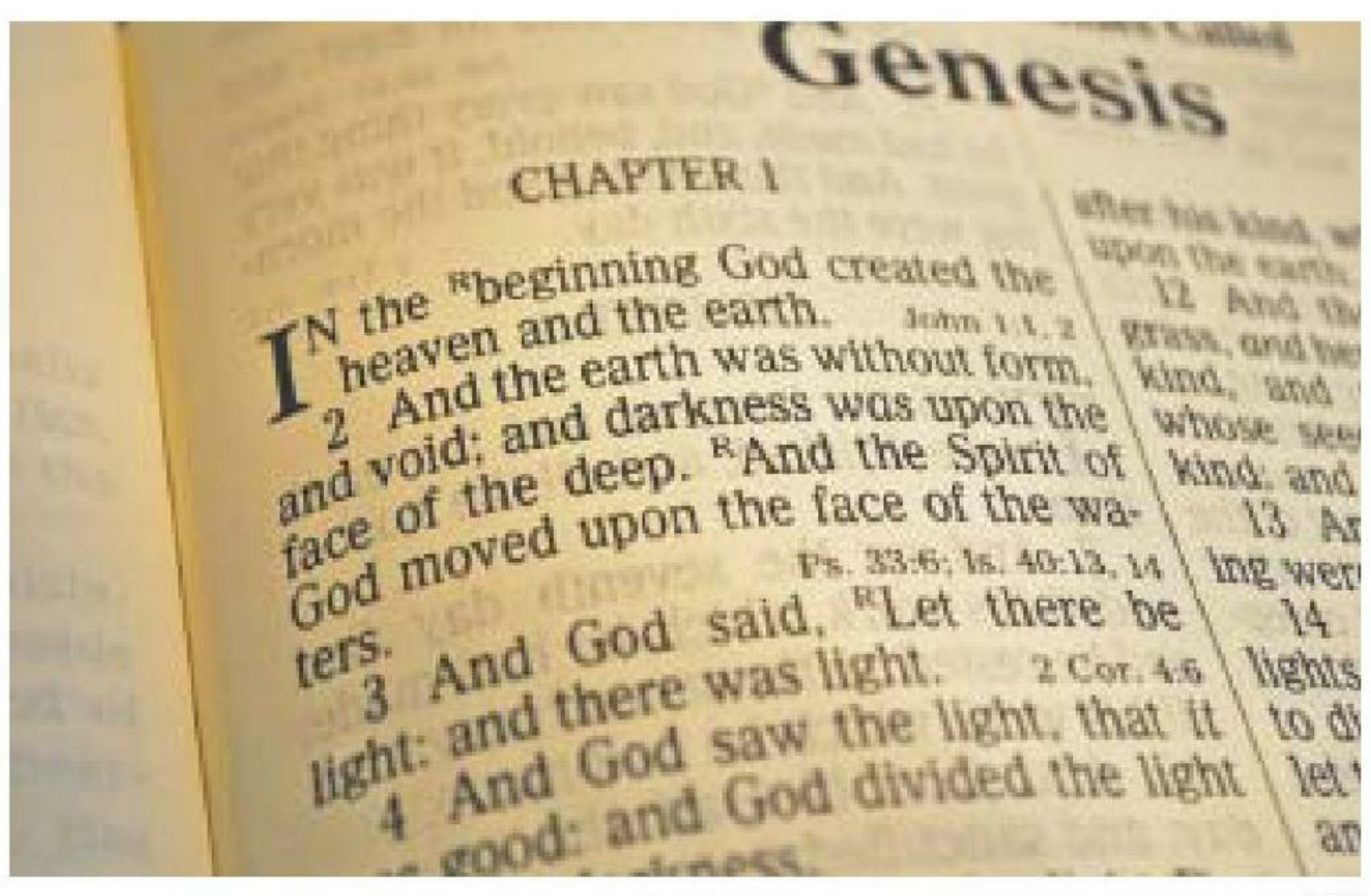
“For nearly 50 years, they have been on view at the Norton Simon Museum and will continue to be accessible to the public for years to come,” the statement said.

Pawel Sawicki, a spokesperson for the Auschwitz Memorial, said the watercolors of Roma victims that Gottliebova Babbitt was forced to paint by Mengele to document his horrendous experiments and racial research, “must remain in the Memorial” to document the man’s crimes.

While he understands the family’s sentiments, Sawicki said the portraits of Roma and Sinti victims are among the few remaining documents of Mengele’s criminal experiments and should be treated as historical documents of the Auschwitz concentration camp.

MONDAY EVENING TELEVISION SCHEDULE

	CHATT	EPB	7 PM	7:30	8 PM	8:30	9 PM	9:30	10 PM	10:30
3.1 NBC	4	3	ET (N)	Inside (N)	The Voice "The Blind Auditions Season Premiere" (SP) (N)				Line of Fire "Pilot" 'TV14' (N)	
3.2 DABL	216		Jamie Foxx	Jamie Foxx	Martin	Martin	Martin	Martin	Living Single	Living Single
3.3 ION	178	22	(:55) Chicago P.D.		Chicago P.D.		Chicago P.D. "Fighting Ghosts"		Chicago P.D. "White Knuckle"	
3.4 TrueR	217	460	Hudson & Rex		Hudson & Rex		Hudson & Rex		Hudson & Rex	
6.1 Heartland		165	Heartland		The Dailey &	The Dailey &	Common Strings		*Esther* Louise Lombard 'TVPG'	
6.2 RTVN			Doctor Who	Doctor Who	The Carol Burnett Show		21 Jump Street		Wiseguy "Dead Right" 'TV14'	
6.3 REV'N			Wiseguy "A Rightful Place"		Inside	The Front Row	Drag Racing		*The Time of Your Life* 'TVG'	
6.4 ACT			Wiseguy "A Rightful Place"		The Inside	The Front Row	400 Thunder		*The Time of Your Life* 'TVG'	
6.5 Family			Road Trip	LOST IN	★★ *Gunfight at Red Sands* (1965,Western) Richard Harrison				Biographies & Icons	
9.1 ABC	10	9	Wheel (N)	Jeopardy! (N)	Kickoff (N) /(:15) NFL Football New York Giants at Los Angeles Rams (N)					
9.2 FOX	11	7	Big Bang	Big Bang	Name That Tune (N)		The Weakest Link (N)		News at 10 (L) (N)	
9.3 TBD			Funniest Home Videos		Whose Line Is	Whose Line Is	Whose Line Is	Whose Line Is	Saturday Night Live	
12.1 CBS	13	12	Prime News	Prime News	FBI "3 Up, 3 Down" 'TV14'		CIA "Forbidden Eye" 'TV14'		FBI "Shahadah" 'TV14'	
12.2 Bounce	208	162	(6:30) ★★ *Tyler Perry's Daddy's Little Girls* 'TVG'				★★ *Just Wright* (2010,Romance) Queen Latifah 'TVG'			
12.3 Escape			NCIS: New Orleans		NCIS: New Orleans		NCIS: New Orleans		NCIS: New Orleans	
12.4 Grit			Wanted ...	Wanted ...	★ *Canadian Pacific* (1949,Western) Randolph Scott 'TVG'				★★ *Cariboo Trail* 'TVG'	
18.1 GPB	204	10	Antiques Roadshow		Antiques Roadshow (N)		New York/Documentary "Shadows of the Past" 'TV14' (N)			
18.2 Create			Table	Cook's Country	Test Kitchen	Food	Mexican	Mexican	R. Steves	Weekends
18.3 Know			Innovation	Innovation	GSUTV	Coyote Crossing 'TVPG'		GSUTV	PBS News Hour (N)	
18.4			Lyla	Arthur	Nature Cat	Elementary	Cyberchase	Let's Go Luna!	Phoebe & Jay	Xavier Riddle
23.1 TBN	9	13	Allen	Stakelbeck	Praise		Takeaway Kirk 'TVG'		Harvest With	Stakelbeck
23.2 Hillsong			Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.
23.3 Smile		159	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.	Paid Prog.
23.4 Enlace		158	(6:00) Enlace TV						Enlace TV	
23.5		156	(5:30) *Southern Gospel*		*Left Behind: Rise of the Antichrist* A new leader controls the UN after millions vanish.					
39.1 CTTV			★★ *Moonfall* ('22) Astronauts must stop the moon from crashing into Earth. Halle Berry 'TVG'						*Tyler Perry's Good Deeds*	
45.1 PBS	5	5	PBS News Hour (N)		Antiques Roadshow (N)		New York/Documentary "Shadows of the Past" 'TV14' (N)			
45.2 Create	201	164	Table	Cook's Country	Test Kitchen	Food	Mexican	Mexican	R. Steves	Weekends
45.3			Lyla	Arthur	Nature Cat	Elementary	Cyberchase	Let's Go Luna!	Phoebe & Jay	Xavier Riddle
53.1 CW	6	6	Family Feud	Family Feud	All American "Finish Line" (N)		Penn & Teller: Fool Us		National (N)	National (N)
53.2 MyTV	226	8	Live PD	Live PD	Chicago Fire "Superhero"		Chicago Fire		Sports (N)	TBA
53.3 MeTV	225	166	M*A*S*H	M*A*S*H	Andy Griffith	Andy Griffith	Raymond	Raymond	Golden Girls	Golden Girls
53.4 Charge!			Criminal Minds "Exit Wounds"		Criminal Minds		Law Order: CI "Players" 'TV14'		Law Order: CI "Silencer" 'TV14'	
61.1 ThisTV	208	169	Murder USA "CLANTON" 'TV14'		Heartland Homicide		Killer Cases		Crime Stories	
61.2			Grimm "Face Off" 'TV14'		Grimm "Natural Born Wesen"		The X-Files "Existence" 'TV14'		The X-Files	


TNS

Believers in Jesus are God’s faithful citizens

Q: What does it mean for Christians to be citizens of Heaven and Earth? — C.C.

Billy Graham

A: Believers in Jesus — those who have been saved and obey God’s Word — are citizens of God’s kingdom. The Bible says that the kingdom of God is within them.

While good citizens (many who are believers in Christ) give allegiance to their country, Christians also give ultimate allegiance to the highest authority — Almighty God — while still living in an alien world as pilgrims and strangers.

The world as it is known is under the rule and reign of the prince of this world — Satan.

But from the cross of Christ, Jesus has conquered Satan, and all those who have accepted Jesus as Lord have been reconciled to God who reigns as King in their hearts.

Jesus dwells within the believer through His Holy Spirit and He desires that all people know the joy of His great salvation.

My Answer

The crucified and risen King has all authority, and His indwelling Spirit is greater than Satan and his demon powers.

“The one who is in you is greater than the one who is in the world” (1 John 4:4, NIV).

The signs of the Kingdom are not political, although they may have political implications.

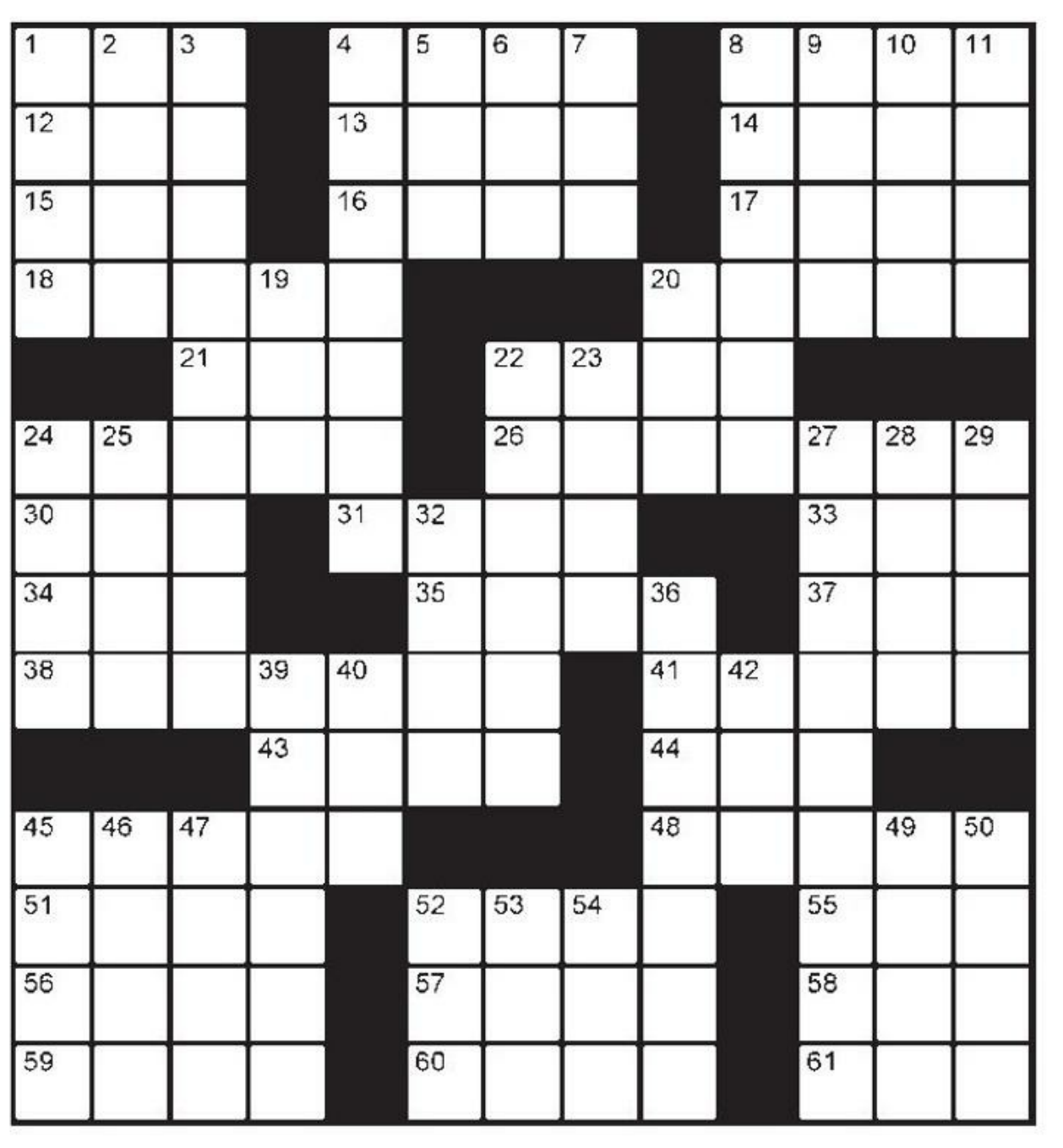
Jesus’ signs were given to lead people to faith in Him, not to political reform.

Jesus, by His Spirit, draws sinners to the cross, leading men and women to reconciliation with God, which then produces peace in the hearts of those who believe in Him.

His kingdom will one day come to this earth. In the meantime, God reigns supreme over the world, leading it providentially toward His perfect will, and His will is for all people to commit to Christ and live for Him.

This column is based on the words and writings of the late Rev. Billy Graham.

NEA DAILY CROSSWORD PUZZLE



ACROSS
1 Vessel with a cork
4 Bivouac
8 Word of regret
12 Mil. address part
13 Musical instrument
14 Penalty
15 Racket
16 Small salamander
17 Crumbly cheese
18 — — the line
20 Last
21 Work in verse
22 Entry barrier
24 Joins with a torch
26 Designate, said of funds
30 Black cuckoo
31 Lustrous fabric
33 Actor — Aykroyd
34 “— Got a Secret”
35 Miss America’s accessory
37 Contend
38 Despotism
41 White poplar
43 Morsels
44 Director — Howard
45 Play for time
48 Photo finish
51 Molten rock
52 U2 lead singer
55 Web address
56 State near Nev.
57 Soon
58 Caviar
59 Pie a la —
60 Theater award
61 Storm’s center

DOWN
1 Green gem
2 “— — Smoke”
3 Boatman in Venice
4 Admit wrongdoing
5 Honest —
6 Cut down grass
7 Favorite
8 Say with confidence
9 Claim on properly
10 Architectural pier
11 Close
19 Peculiar
20 Favoring
22 Travel disruptions
23 Leafy trees
24 Hold off
25 A deadly sin
27 “Bill & Ted’s Excellent —”
28 Marsh bird
29 Patella
32 “— It Romantic?”
36 Accord
39 Burning
40 Nothing
42 Feather scarf
45 Shut with force
46 Poi source
47 Eager
49 Helen of —
50 Gen. Robert — —
52 Cudgel
53 Artist Yoko —
54 Oui’s opposite

ANSWER TO SATURDAY’S PUZZLE

D	A	M	■	W	A	K	E	■	P	A	R	■
I	V	Y	■	O	P	E	N	■	A	R	U	M
V	E	T	■	R	E	N	O	■	G	A	L	E
A	S	H	E	S	■	O	C	T	O	B	E	R
■	■	O	V	E	N	■	H	O	D	■	■	■
S	I	L	E	N	C	E	■	P	A	C	T	S
A	M	O	R	■	A	G	T	■	■	L	E	E
G	I	G	■	■	A	G	O	■	B	O	R	E
S	T	Y	L	E	■	S	O	J	O	U	R	N
■	■	■	O	L	D	■	L	E	N	D	■	■
A	B	D	O	M	E	N	■	S	O	N	G	S
S	L	A	M	■	B	O	A	T	■	I	R	A
K	I	T	E	■	I	D	L	E	■	N	O	N
■	P	A	D	■	T	E	A	R	■	E	W	E

CELEBRITY CIPHER

By Luis Campos

Celebrity Cipher cryptograms are created from quotations by famous people, past and present. Each letter in the cipher stands for another.

“JTSY MLY ZG LIVSXDHX ... MTXD GNI’QX L HNZSH, GNI KN JN NUXD ZSH DSKTJY. MTXD GNI’QX L RSV, GNI KN JN GNIQ HFLYY.” — QLUTLXF ONO-MLRYOXQK

Previous Solution: “I find it hard to watch a lot of the kind of things I’m doing before doing it ... It makes me too aware.” — Daniel Kaluuya

TODAY’S CLUE: *T equals H*

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